

How Do We Identify Food Security in the Past?



How Do We Identify Food Security in the Past?

Before continuing, make sure you have read the supplementary reading by Amanda Logan (2016).

Logan uses definitions of food security from the WHO (World Health Organization of the United Nations) and the FAO to identify four aspects of food security that can be investigated archaeologically and historically:

- Food *availability* – Sufficient quantities of food available on a consistent basis.
- Food *access* – Sufficient resources to obtain appropriate foods for a nutritious diet.
- Food *use* – Appropriate use based on knowledge of basic nutrition and sanitation.
- Food *preference* – The ability to exercise choice in what foods are eaten.

Logan argues that these four aspects should all be considered when exploring food security in the past. Simply having enough food is insufficient: That food also needs to be available to everyone, and they should have access to the foods that they prefer and find satisfying. The tools used by archaeologists to identify food scarcity represent one way to study food security but are insufficient to identify whether everyone has access to preferred, satisfying food. Careful archaeological study of an entire community can potentially indicate whether the food is evenly distributed and available to all, or restricted to specific groups within that society. To best address the social meaning of food, however, and whether preferred and satisfying foods are available, additional information about cultural norms and preferences is needed. The best sources of this information are historical documents or **ethnographic analogy**.

Ethnographic analogy is the use of ethnographic study of a contemporary human society to make inferences about the beliefs and practices of a society in the past that is no longer observable directly. This method is considered stronger when the group used as the ethnographic case is a good technological and ecological parallel to a past society; for example, the ethnographic study of Marsh Arabs who inhabited the swampy areas of the Tigris and Euphrates Rivers of southern Iraq

provided valuable insights into how ancient Sumerians inhabited similar landscapes in southern Iraq thousands of years earlier. Identifying cultural connections among descendent groups also strengthens the validity of this approach. Puebloan communities of New Mexico, whom ethnographers from the Smithsonian lived with and studied in the 19th century, have clear cultural connections with the Ancestral Puebloan communities who built such famous archaeological sites as Chaco Canyon and Mesa Verde. Understanding Puebloan religion helps archaeologists understand the function of specific rooms in archaeological sites across the region.

A Case Study of Food Security: Banda, Ghana

Logan uses ethnography, oral history, and historical documents in concert with archaeology to study the long-term food security of Banda, Ghana. Her primary archaeological dataset is the paleoethnobotanical study of what people in the area of Banda ate over the last thousand years. While other scholars have argued that climate change is a primary factor in food availability, Logan documents evidence of food security even during past periods when conditions were substantially drier than the present.

Consider the following questions to guide your understanding of the article:

- How did food availability change over time? What evidence is used by Logan to reconstruct food availability?
- How did food access change over time? What evidence is used by Logan to reconstruct food access?
- How did the ability of residents of Banda to exercise food preference change over time? What evidence is used by Logan to identify the availability of preferred foods?
- What was the unique role of maize in this society? Was the introduction of maize beneficial or detrimental to residents of Banda, and why?
- How did economic and personal security change over time in relation to food security? When did a decline in either economic or personal security (or both) lead to a decline in food security? Why did this occur sometimes, but not others?

This article, and our discussion of it, should help you understand how archaeologists can apply modern concepts to study human societies in the past. This article also indicates the importance of using ethnographic and historical information to contextualize preference in the past, which gives archaeologists a better understanding of a past society's lived experience.